

A River Runs Through It

A journey through three countries along the mighty Indus finds pieces of the complex puzzle that is the subcontinent's heritage



EMPIRES OF THE INDUS: THE STORY OF A RIVER
by ALICE ALBINIA
John Murray/Hachette India
Price: Rs 550; Pages: 384

■ By Sam Miller

Alice Albinia's remarkable first book is the story of her meandering journey up the River Indus, from its mouth near Karachi to its source in Tibet. She zigzags her way across Pakistan, following tributaries of the Indus which flow into India and Afghanistan, before returning to the parent river as its courses through Ladakh and then on to Mount Kailash. But she also takes her readers back in time as she heads doggedly northwards. So, for instance, she uses Karachi as her location for discussing Partition and its effects, then Nankana Sahib to tell the story of early Sikhism, the valley of Swat to follow the trail of Alexander the Great, and finally to Tibet to describe how, 50 million years ago, the Himalayas and Indus were created by the crunching together of two continents.

Albinia comes across as trusting, foolhardy, and extremely well-read—all preconditions of great travel writing. Her passionate and beautifully written preface sets out her stall. Albinia was working as a journalist in Delhi when she realised on reading the Rig Veda that "Hinduism's motherland was not in India but Pakistan, its demonised neighbour". As she travelled to Pakistan, she found that "the river gave logic to my own explo-

rations... (and it) runs through the lives of its people like a charm". The book is at its very best when telling forgotten stories—about the Bhangis of Karachi, the Sikhs of Pakistani Punjab or the Dards of Upper Indus. Her chapter on the more than one million Africans (the Sheedis) of southern Sindh is exceptional, both for its sensitive and intelligent portrayal of this community, as also for its reflections on South Asian attitudes towards the colour of the skin. Her decision to use Karachi, and not Punjab, to tell the story of Partition throws a new, quite different light on the traumas of 1947. There are also moments of terrible, painful humour. Normally, when travelling in the tribal areas of north-west Pakistan, she would stay in the women's quarters of a house—but once, to her astonishment, she was given a mattress in the male-only *hujra*. She asked why, and discovered that previous female visitors, from an Islamabad-based NGO, had taught the women about sex, "how they should suck this

thing, lick that, go on top of their husbands". The women of the household were since then no longer allowed to share a room with female visitors.

Empires of the Indus does have a few moments of flatness. The chapter on British explorers is cluttered with facts and is rather downbeat like a cut-down PhD thesis. Her coverage of the Pashtuns on both sides of the Durand Line smacks of cliché. She describes the Kabul River as "brown with silt, and turbulent with Pashtun intrigue". She dons, like so many western travellers before her, a burqa—only to discover that her way of walking, her *chaal*, immediately identifies her as a foreigner. There are also minor errors: the centre of Babar's Indian empire was Agra not Delhi; Babar was a descendant of Timur on his father's—not his mother's—side; and Dara Shikoh was not assassinated "after a dramatic river-battle on the Indus". The Ismailis will be more than surprised to learn that their "holy book" is not the Quran, and that they consider the Prophet Mohammad and his son-in-law Ali to be the ninth and tenth avatars of Vishnu—though admittedly this is a popular teaching found in Ismaili devotional songs known as *ginans*.

But overall, *Empires of the Indus* is an excellent example of a readable book that deals with serious social and historical issues. It challenges many of the binary divisions prevalent in South Asia: between India and Pakistan, between Hindus and Muslims, between conservatives and liberals, and between men and women in a thoughtful and unpatronising way. "Today," argues Albinia, perhaps a little over-optimistically, "in spite of the militarised borders that divide the river's people from each other, the ancient interconnectedness of the Indus still prevails." Let's hope she's right. ■



TIMELESS RIPPLES: A Hindu version of hell as a river in the Sadhubela temple in Pakistan (left); painting of the Indus River God Uderol in Zindapir temple in Pakistan

